Lesson 31

THE AUTHORITY OF THE BIBLE

Aim: To establish the Bible as the sole source of authority for the believer.

Introduction:

“It is impossible to rightly govern the world without God and Bible.” - George Washington, First President of the United States

Richard Hooker, one the greatest English Theologians, listed three possible sources of authority; the Bible, the church and human reason. Catholics emphasize the authority of the church, evangelicals emphasize the authority of the Bible and emphasize the authority of reason.

I. THE AUTHORITY OF OLD TESTAMENT

The phrase "Thus saith the Lord, or its equivalent, occurs more than 2,000 times in the Old Testament.

A. Testimony of its writers:

1. David.

2 Samuel 23:2-2 *“The Spirit of the LORD spoke through me; his word was on my tongue.”*

2. Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 1:9 “*9 Then the LORD reached out his hand and touched my mouth and said to me, “I have put my words in your mouth.”*

3. Ezekiel 3:4 *4 He then said to me: “Son of man, go now to the people of Israel and speak my words to them.*

B. Testimony of Christ.

1. Matthew 5:17-18.17 *“Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. 18For truly I tell you, until heaven and earth disappear, not the smallest letter, not the least stroke of a pen, will by any means disappear from the Law until everything is accomplished.”*

2. John 5:39 *39 You study the Scriptures diligently because you think that in them you have eternal life. These are the very Scriptures that testify about me.*

C. Testimony of the Apostles

It is evident from their inspired writing that the Apostles of Christ considered the Old Testament scriptures prophetic and inseparable from the authority, power and ministry of Christ. Paul says- the whole Old Testament is inspired by God.

2 Timothy 3:16-17. *16All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, 17so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work.*

II. THE AUTHORITY OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

A. The authority given the Apostle by Christ

John 17:18 *18As you sent me into the world, I have sent them into the world.*

John 20:21 *21Again Jesus said, "Peace be with you! As the Father has sent me, I am sending you."*

B. The apostles wrote under Christ's authority. Paul received what he preached from the Lord.

1 Corinthians 11:23 *23For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took bread,*

Galatians 1:11,12 *11I want you to know, brothers and sisters that the gospel I preached is not of human origin.*

12 I did not receive it from any man, nor was I taught it; rather, I received it by revelation from Jesus Christ.

The writer of Hebrews got his authority through Christ.

Hebrews 1:1,2 *1In the past God spoke to our ancestors through the prophets at many times and in various ways, 2but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son, whom he appointed heir of all things, and through whom also he made the universe.*

III. CONCLUSION

The Bible is the Word of God. As such, it should serve as the one and only source of authority for us believers in all our dealings with God and with man.